

Unhappily HARRIED

By Swagata Sen and
Arvind Chhabra in Shimla

This is one Shimla Declaration that adds an intriguing twist to the meaning of freedom and independence. While Prime Minister Manmohan Singh spoke of the nation's growth in his Independence Day address in the Capital, in Shimla, the summer capital under the British, a group of men and women at that very moment declared they were better off in the British Raj. That freedom to them was still a dream. The Save Indian Family Foundation (SIFF) comprises young, angry, "harassed" husbands, who claim they represent 25 NGOs and 40,000 equally "tortured" persons like them. Their grouse: they were being "betrayed" by those who framed laws and enforced them; that the law erroneously assumed all wives were "innocent angels" who could only be sinned against, and are not sinners. At the end of the two-day meet, the participants announced that they would no longer take things lying down and declared the SIFF's Shimla Declaration that Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code and Domestic Violence Act, 2005, was "unconstitutional".

Flashing their red caps and attired in colourful T-shirts with slogans loudly decrying 498A and certain other laws, about 100 key members of the SIFF spat venom. To them 498A is the biggest evil and they spoke of it as our freedom fighters did of the Rowlatt Act and Simon Commission, calling it equally draconian. When asked about their wives, they retorted: "Ex-wife, please." But was

Harassed husbands come together in Shimla on Independence Day to protest against cruel treatment by their wives

she a housewife, was the next question? "No, a house-breaking wife." And they screamed in unison: "Do as we say to save the families."

There's a little known world in urban India which seems ridiculous in its existence. "Help, my wife beats me," could only invite guffaws from people around you with specific notions of male domination, and you might even be relegated to the lunatic fringe of society. But the complaints extend to strange circles. As in the case of a senior IAS official and the principal secretary of the West Bengal Government who wouldn't find food for dinner day after day because his wife threw it all away and a software engineer whose harassment was so severe that a high court judge termed it "legal terrorism".

At the Shimla conference, SIFF members sounded agitated. Each one

had his sad story to share. Like Pune-based software engineer Atit, 29, who was booked under Section 498A just because he had asked his wife to take adequate rest and proper medicines instead of attending late-night movies and day-long shopping while she was unwell. Nagpur-based real estate agent Rajesh Vakharia was put behind bars as his wife had filed a false dowry harassment case against him because she didn't get along well with Vakharia and wanted separation.

For a long time, these were stray cases, but now the country's harassed husbands and their families have decided to unite. They feel that they have enough evidence to show that "men's welfare" is as important as women's rights issues in India, and they are making a consolidated effort to make it known to the Government.

What started as a small group on



ANIL DAYAL